DESIGNING EXPERIENCES FOR INFORMAL SOCIAL GATHERINGS

making it easier, smarter, and more engaging

What are Informal Social Gatherings?

Informal social gatherings are events where people meet socially, casually or culturally, but the host manages everything themselves instead of hiring professionals.

Typical Settings

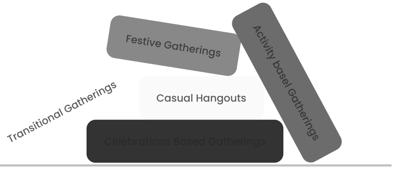
- Homes
- Society / community spaces
- Small private setups

In Scope

- Small-scale gatherings (10–50 people)
- Informal, personal, or cultural events
- Host-led planning and coordination

What are we excluding?

- Large-scale events
- Hotel or banquet-based events
- Fully managed professional services



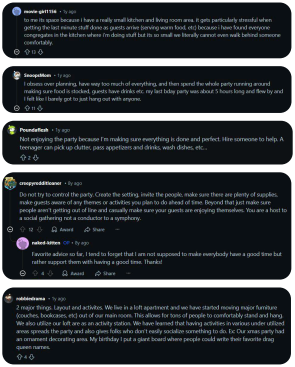
They include

Why They Matter ?

Informal Social Gatherings are the **most common form of social interaction,** playing an important role in everyday life. They help people **build personal connections,** strengthen relationships, and create meaningful memories. Unlike large-scale events, they happen more frequently and focus on the quality of experience and bonding rather than size or scale.

To understand this domain, we started by exploring existing knowledge:

SECONDARY RESEARCH



movie-girl1156 • 1y ago
to me its space because i have a really small kitchen and living room area. it gets particularly stressful when getting the last minute stuff done as guests arrive (serving warm food, etc) because i have found everyone congregates in the kitchen where i'm doing stuff but its so small we literally cannot even walk behind someone comfortably.
13

SnoopsMom • 1y ago
I obsess over planning, have way too much of everything, and then spend the whole party running around making sure food is stocked, guests have drinks etc. my last bday party was about 5 hours long and flew by and I felt like I barely got to just hang out with anyone.
11

Poundaflesh • 1y ago
Not enjoying the party because I'm making sure everything is done and perfect. Hire someone to help. A teenager can pick up clutter, pass appetizers and drinks, wash dishes, etc...
2

creepyredditloaner • 8y ago
Do not try to control the party. Create the setting, invite the people, make sure there are plenty of supplies, make guests aware of any themes or activities you plan to do ahead of time. Beyond that just make sure people aren't getting out of line and casually make sure your guests are enjoying themselves. You are a host to a social gathering not a conductor to a symphony.
12 Award Share ···

naked-kitten OP • 8y ago
Favorite advice so far, I tend to forget that I am not supposed to make everybody have a good time but rather support them with having a good time. Thanks!
4 Award Share ···

robbiedrama • 1y ago
2 major things. Layout and activites. We live in a loft apartment and we have started moving major furniture (couches, bookcases, etc) out of our main room. This allows for tons of people to comfortably stand and hang. We also utilize our loft are as an activity station. We have learned that having activities in various under utilized areas spreads the party and also gives folks who don't easily socialize something to do. Ex: Our xmas party had an ornament decorating area. My birthday I put a giant board where people could write their favorite drag queen names.
4

Source: Reddit

"Gatherings are meant to connect people, not drain the person who planned them."
Hosting Burnout Is Real (Even for Small Gatherings)
— Woman Around Town

"Micro events still require some serious planning due to their complexity."
The Micro-event Revolution: How Smaller Gatherings Are Making a Big Impact
— Bizzabo

"Experience-led services increasingly require journey-level coordination and personalization across touchpoints."
Personalization & Experience Economy research
— Deloitte

"You spend the evening checking the kitchen instead of sitting down."
Hosting Burnout Is Real (Even for Small Gatherings)
— Woman Around Town

"Hosting becomes another thing to manage in a life that already feels full."
Hosting Burnout Is Real (Even for Small Gatherings)
— Woman Around Town

"Micro events are highly interactive & personalized, requiring more attention"
Micro Events: Personalized Approaches to Event Planning
— Catersource

"Urban Indians increasingly prefer small, frequent social interactions over large events due to time constraints and lifestyle changes."
Consumer Lifestyle Trends Report
— KPMG India

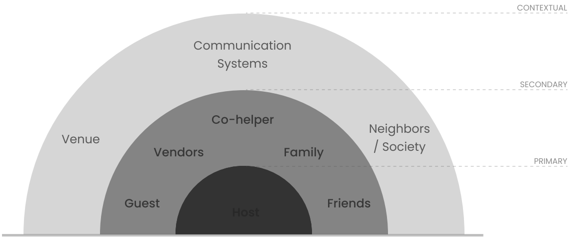
"Preparation reduces day-of stress significantly"
Hosting a Dinner Party? Here's What Not to Do
— Better Homes & Gardens

Note: Since limited research directly addresses informal small-gatherings, we mapped insights from adjacent hosting and event literature, globally to support and validate patterns observed in our domain study to have an idea. Link is provided below the quotes!

INSIGHTS WE FOUND FROM SECONDARY RESEARCH

- **Support exists but is unstructured**
  People rely on friends/family instead of formal or reliable systems
- **Micro-events are highly personalized but lacktools**
  Each event is unique, yet current solutions are designed for large, standardized events
- **Critical moments define the experience**
  Setup, guest arrival, and engagement flow have the highest coordination pressure
- **Fragmentation increases cognitive load** as hosts must coordinate across multiple sources without a unified way to compare options, evaluate reliability, or make informed decisions.

There is an opportunity to design a system that redistributes responsibilities, structures interaction, and enables more engaging and balanced social experiences.



Stakeholders

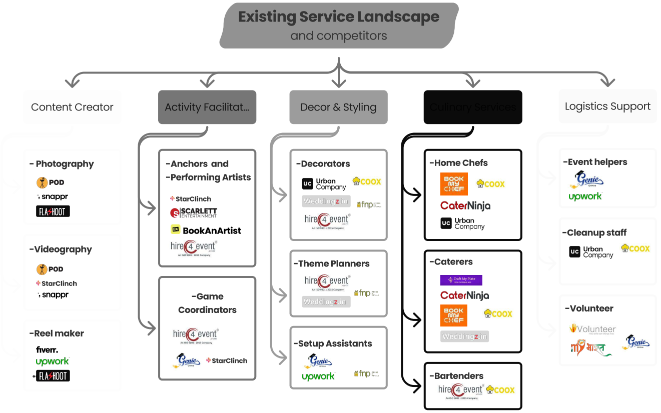
THE REFERRAL CHAIN PROBLEM

Before turning to any app or platform, the typical Indian host first reaches out to someone they trust. This word-of-mouth system is deeply embedded in social culture - someone heard about a good anchor at a neighbour's Diwali party, or a relative recommended a home chef from the last Navratri gathering. This trust network works, but it is completely unstructured: no way to compare options, no transparent pricing, unknown availability, and no accountability if something goes wrong. Anyone outside this circle someone new to a city, a younger host, or someone planning an unfamiliar type of event has no reliable path to find help.

This referral gap is where the market opportunity begins.

MARKET MAPPING

We mapped all available services related to event management to understand what already exists.


Existing Service Landscape
and competitors

Content Creator
- Photography
POD
snappr
FLASHOOT
-Videography
POD
StarClinch
snappr
-Reel maker
fiverr.
upwork
FLASHOOT

Activity Facilitat...
-Anchors and
-Performing Artists
StarClinch
SCARLETT ENTERTAINMENT
BookAnArtist
hire4event
-Game Coordinators
hire4event
Genie
StarClinch

Decor & Styling
-Decorators
Urban Company
COOX
Weddingz.in
fnp
hire4event
-Theme Planners
hire4event
fnp
Weddingz.in
-Setup Assistants
Genie
upwork
fnp

Culinary Services
-Home Chefs
BOOK MY CHEF
COOX
CaterNinja
Urban Company
-Caterers
Craft My Plate
CaterNinja
BOOK MY CHEF
COOX
Weddingz.in
-Bartenders
hire4event
COOX

Logistics Support
-Event helpers
Genie
upwork
-Cleanup staff
Urban Company
COOX
-Volunteer
Volunteer
मेरा भारत
Genie

Before identifying gaps, we explored every category of service a host might need. We found that **existing services are highly fragmented** each platform or provider covers only one slice of the hosting experience and no single platform for informal gathering

We then zoomed in on the most structured players — who are they and what are the gaps in Existing Platform

Existing Platfrom	COOX	StarClinch	Urban Company	Hire4Event
About	COOX is India's leading platform for booking home services like professional chefs, domestic cooks, bartenders, waiters, kitchen cleaners, live singers, appliances and crockery on rent, designer cakes, ingredients delivery and event decoration	A marketplace for booking performance artists and live entertainers — singers, comedians, DJs, dancers, photographers, and anchors — primarily for weddings and corporate events.	An Indian home services platform offering beauty, cleaning, repairs, home chefs, and on-demand domestic help	A full-service corporate event management and artist booking company using AR, VR, and AI for large-scale conferences, exhibitions, product launches, and corporate offsites across India and internationally.
What it doesn't do	There is no event planning, no guest engagement support, and no associate chosen by the user — COOX assigns its own professional with fixed rate.	Purely a discovery-and-booking platform. No planning tools, no coordination support, no on-ground presence beyond the performer, only for big events	Designed for individual services, not event hosting journeys. No planning layer, no event-specific coordinator, no engagement or post-event specific support.	Built entirely for corporate and large-scale events.
User picks their associate?	No	Yes	Yes	No
On-ground event support?	Food only	Performer only	Task-by-task	Full (B2B)
Guest engagement support?	No	No	No	No
Planning help provided?	No	no	no	yes (cooperate only)
Serves informal gatherings?	Yes	No	Partially	no

What did we learn?

1. The market is fragmented, not absent

Every category of service exists — chefs, decorators, anchors, cleaners, photographers. But a host still has to discover, contact, compare, negotiate, and coordinate each one individually, which is exactly the cognitive load our research identified as the core problem

2. No platform is designed for informal gatherings at home.

The services were built for scale - corporate events, weddings, banquet-hall functions. Informal gatherings with 10–50 people at someone's home have no dedicated platform designed around their unique needs, constraints, and emotional dynamics.

3. The referral system is the real competition

The biggest competitor isn't an app — it's the existing social network. People ask a trusted contact, who recommends someone they know. This system has trust but no structure, no comparison, no accountability, and no access for people outside the circle.

After this background, we conducted

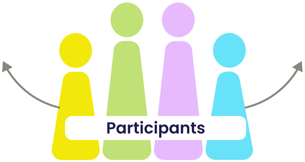
PRIMARY RESEARCH

to understand how small social gatherings are currently planned, experienced, and managed. Participants included a diverse mix of hosts across different types of informal gatherings

9 **Semi-structured interviews** — Link to Docs — **Methodology** — Link to Sheet — **23** **Servey**

HOSTS

- Celebration Host
- Casual event Host
- Festive event host



SERVICE PROVIDERS

- Emerging
  (students, hobbyists)
- Experienced
  (anchors, hosts, creators)

Hosts Insights

1. Host is unable to enjoy their own event

As they are simultaneously managing everything, which is unsaid for a host. we also, found that this happens as long as they are the only one monitoring whether the evening is working,

We should design a product that takes over the watching role — something that tracks the room, notices what's off, and acts on it — so the host can stop being the operator and finally be a guest.

2. Helpers Don't Actually Help

Hosts have willing helpers around them but asking for help creates a second job on top of the first — explaining the vision, correcting the execution, managing the helper's feelings when things go wrong. By the time the task is done right, the host has spent more energy than if they had just done it themselves. The help is there. The understanding is not.

Because we found that hosts end up managing their helpers more than the event itself, we should design a product that carries the host's vision independently — so the right thing gets done at the right moment without the host having to explain, correct, or follow up.

3. Gathering hits a dead zone

Conversations dry up, phones come out, and the room quietly splits into separate clusters, the energy that took hours to build disappears in minutes. Both happen predictably, at every event, every time. Yet every host is caught off guard and improvises alone , grabbing props, deploying chai, physically rotating between groups, using their own energy as the only tool. When it doesn't work, they take it personally.

Because the gathering loses its reason to stay together, we should design a product that suggests the right thing to do at the right moment based on who is in the room and how the evening is going ,so the host never has to scramble to save it.

4. Post event phase is broken

The event finishes but the host's brain doesn't. Guests leave, say "it was amazing," and move on by morning. The host is still awake replaying everything that went wrong. There is no moment of closure — no one to say "you did it, it's done, let it go." The evening just trails off into exhaustion and second-guessing.

Because we found that hosts have no way to close the loop after an event ends, we should design a post-event feature that seals the evening — acknowledges what was built, names what worked, and gives the host a clear moment to put it down.

5. The final 60–90 minutes before guests arrive is peak chaos

Every other part of the evening has the energy of the room to carry it. This window has nothing just the host, alone, trying to finish everything while mentally preparing to be present for everyone about to walk in.

Because we found that the final 90 minutes before guests arrive is the most compressed, most unassisted moment in the entire hosting journey, the host is still cooking, still setting up, not yet dressed, clock running out, so we should design a setup assistance for exactly this window, someone or something that takes the next three things off the host's list without being asked, so the host walks into their own event ready, not frantic.

6. Identity is the key decision driver to seeking help

Every host's relationship with help is not about capability or capacity it is about who they are. Before designing any feature or service, the first question is not "what does the host need?" It is "who does this host believe themselves to be?" Because that answer determines everything — what help they will accept, in what form, from whom, and how visible it can be. Identity is not a barrier. It is the brief.

Because we found that a host's identity directly shapes what kind of help they will accept, we should design a product that first understands who the host is — and then offers help in a form that fits that identity rather than challenging it.

Service Providers Insights

7. Unclear Client Expectations Create Confusion

A lack of clear briefs creates uncertainty for providers. Beginners feel anxious about what is expected, while professionals are unable to deliver their best without clarity.

Because we found that ambiguity directly impacts both confidence and performance, so we should design a structured briefing system that defines expectations upfront, so providers can walk in prepared, confident, and aligned with what the client actually wants.

8. Pricing is Confusing and Inconsistent

Pricing remains inconsistent because there is no shared understanding of value. This leads to constant negotiation and often results in providers being undervalued.

Because we found that the absence of standardized value creates friction in every interaction, so we should design a pricing framework that brings clarity and consistency, so providers no longer have to repeatedly justify their pricing.

9. Small Gigs Feel Exhausting, Not Worth It

Small gigs feel unworthy because the effort — travel, setup, coordination — remains the same as larger events, while the returns are significantly lower. This makes them feel draining rather than rewarding.

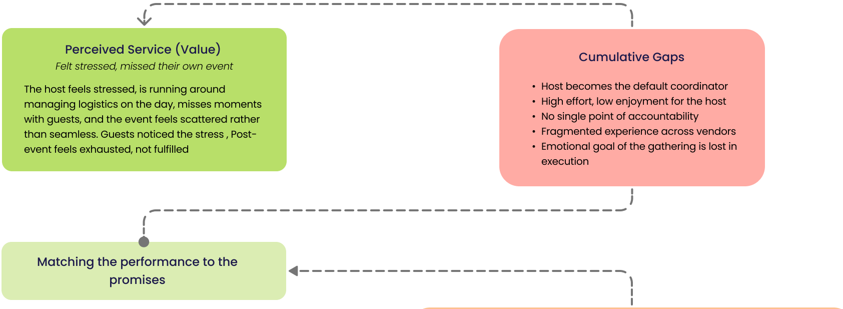
Because we found that the real issue is not the size of the gig, but the inefficiency around it, so we should design a system that optimizes how small gigs are taken up, something that clusters nearby events, so small gigs shift from being exhausting tasks to manageable and profitable opportunities.

7. One System Doesn't Fit All Experience Levels

Service providers operate at very different levels, yet they are all forced to navigate the same unstructured system. Beginners need guidance, mid-level providers need efficiency, and professionals need control.

Because we found that a single system cannot serve all experience levels equally, so we should design an adaptive platform that responds to these differences, so each provider can operate in a way that matches their experience and goals.

GAP MODEL



Perceived Service (Value)

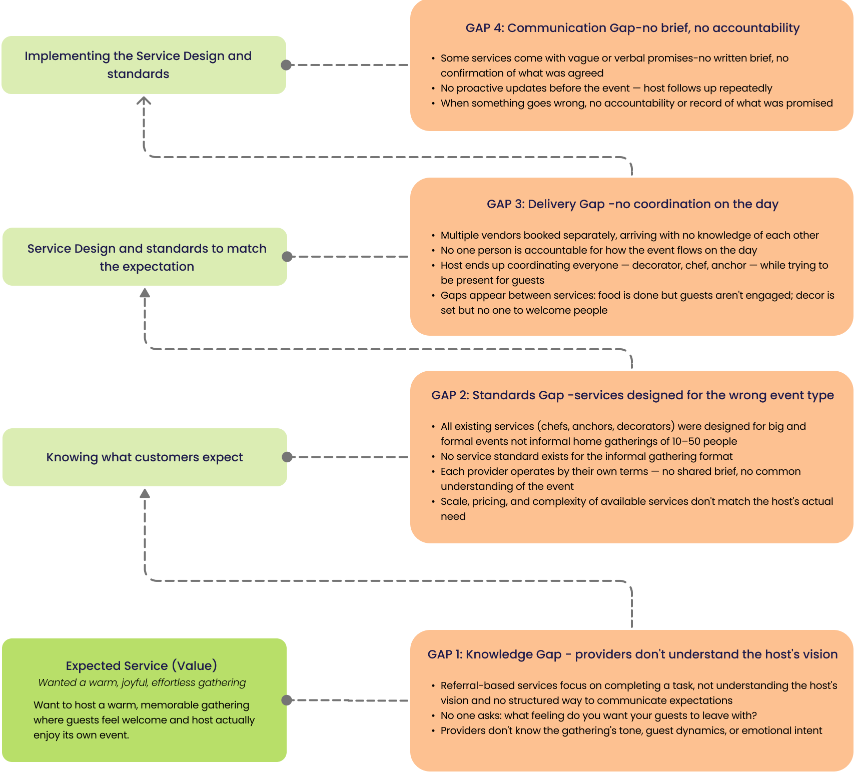
Felt stressed, missed their own event

The host feels stressed, is running around managing logistics on the day, misses moments with guests, and the event feels scattered rather than seamless. Guests noticed the stress , Post-event feels exhausted, not fulfilled

Cumulative Gaps

- Host becomes the default coordinator
- High effort, low enjoyment for the host
- No single point of accountability
- Fragmented experience across vendors
- Emotional goal of the gathering is lost in execution

Matching the performance to the promises



Implementing the Service Design and standards

GAP 4: Communication Gap-no brief, no accountability

- Some services come with vague or verbal promises-no written brief, no confirmation of what was agreed
- No proactive updates before the event — host follows up repeatedly
- When something goes wrong, no accountability or record of what was promised

Service Design and standards to match the expectation

GAP 3: Delivery Gap -no coordination on the day

- Multiple vendors booked separately, arriving with no knowledge of each other
- No one person is accountable for how the event flows on the day
- Host ends up coordinating everyone — decorator, chef, anchor — while trying to be present for guests
- Gaps appear between services: food is done but guests aren't engaged; decor is set but no one to welcome people

Knowing what customers expect

GAP 2: Standards Gap -services designed for the wrong event type

- All existing services (chefs, anchors, decorators) were designed for big and formal events not informal home gatherings of 10–50 people
- No service standard exists for the informal gathering format
- Each provider operates by their own terms — no shared brief, no common understanding of the event
- Scale, pricing, and complexity of available services don't match the host's actual need

Expected Service (Value)

Wanted a warm, joyful, effortless gathering

Want to host a warm, memorable gathering where guests feel welcome and host actually enjoy its own event.

GAP 1: Knowledge Gap - providers don't understand the host's vision

- Referral-based services focus on completing a task, not understanding the host's vision and no structured way to communicate expectations
- No one asks: what feeling do you want your guests to leave with?
- Providers don't know the gathering's tone, guest dynamics, or emotional intent

User Persona

Aarohi

Age
21 years

Occupation
College Student

Location
Tier 2, Lives with family

Tech Comfort
High (WhatsApp, Instagram, Maps)

Event Frequency
Organizes the event | Group size - 10 to 25

About

Aarohi is the person her circle calls when something needs to happen. She views hosting not as a hobby, but as a profound act of love and identity. She is the one who instinctively reads a room, noticing a guest standing alone or a lighting shift that feels slightly "off." For Aarohi, every event is a curated emotional experience where she acts as the director, operations manager, and social anchor all at once. While she takes immense pride in creating "effortless" magic, operating behind the scenes to ensure every detail is seamlessly in place. She is everywhere and nowhere, moving silently between the kitchen and the crowd, serving as the sole person in the room who feels truly responsible for how everyone else feels.

AS-IS HOST JOURNEY MAP

01 **Idea Stage**	02 **Planning & Coordination**	03 **Preparation Stage**	04 **Final Setup Stage**	05 **Guest Arrival Stage**	06 **Event Engagement & Mid-Event Adjustment**	07 **Event Closing Stage**	08 **Reflection Stage**

ACTIONS	Spots an upcoming occasion or impulse Visualises the event mentally Decides the event needs to happen	Polls WhatsApp for guest availability Fixes venue, date, guest list & budget Contacts vendors and caterers Researches decor and activity ideas online Sends reminders and follows up manually	Orders decor, game kits, gifts & groceries Deep cleans the entire house Rechecks food order / caterer status Briefs family or helpers on their roles	Arranges decor, seating & lighting Tests speaker and music Rushes personal preparation last Fixes last-minute gaps alone Does a final walkthrough of the space	Welcomes guests at the door Tracks who has and hasn't arrived Introduces new guests to others Serves snacks and beverages	Serves food and monitors the room Runs games and activities Rotates physically between guest groups Captures moments or delegates to someone Improvises alone when energy drops	Says goodbyes and accepts compliments Settles payments with vendors or helpers Manages full cleanup — dishes, decor, food Sorts what to keep, discard or give away	Scrolls through photos Mentally replays what went wrong Creates reels and posts Shares photos on WhatsApp or Google Drive Passes on vendor referrals by word of mouth
THOUGHTS	*"This needs to happen and if it doesn't workout it won't be right."* *"I think I know exactly what kind of evening this should be."*	*"If I don't coordinate this nobody will confirm and the plan will keep changing."* *"I know exactly how this should feel but I can't explain it to anyone."* *"I need to make sure the food, energy, and venue works for everyone."*	*"Nobody else will do this to the standard I need, so I might do it myself."* *"If I don't do this now I won't have time later."* *"I have everything under control but I'm the only one who knows that."*	*"There's not enough time and I'm the only one who can fix any of this."* *"What did I forget? Is the lighting good or am I lying to myself?"* *"What if no one shows up? What if they show up and they're bored?"*	*"It's working. It actually looks the way I imagined."* *"I need to catch that moment on camera but I also need to be in it."* *"Who doesn't know anyone in this room yet?"* *"What if they show up and they're bored?"*	*"I can't see the whole room at once and things are happening at different corners without me knowing."* *"The groups have stopped talking to each other and I don't know how to fix it."* *"The energy is going and I'm the only one who can see it happening."* *"Why didn't I plan for this? This always happens."*	*"Why do I do this to myself?"* *"I didn't even get to properly talk to the person this was all for."* *"Next time I need a backup."*	*"Uhh. Someone's eyes were closed in the photo."* *"Did the right people feel seen? Was it up to the mark?"* *"It was magical, she said. But was it really?"*
EMOTIONS	😄	🧐	😐	😰	😁	😬	🥹	😮‍💨
Touchpoint	**Digital** Social media, Pinterest, **Human** Past experiences	**Digital** WhatsApp, Google Search, Notes app **Human** Vendors, Friends, Family, Caterers	**Digital** YouTube, Pinterest, Online shopping apps, Vendor DMs **Human** Vendors, Helpers, Family **Physical** Local market, Home space, Grocery items	**Digital** Phone **Human** Family helpers **Physical** Decor items, Speaker & lights, Kitchen	**Digital** Phone (tracking late arrivals) **Human** Guests **Physical** Front door, Entrance space	**Digital** Phone **Human** Guests **Physical** Speaker, Props & game kits, Food & drinks	**Digital** UPI / payment apps **Human** Guests **Physical** Kitchen & dishes, Decor items, Cash	**Digital** Phone gallery, WhatsApp, Instagram, Google Drive
PAIN POINTS	● No structured way to capture or express her vision ● She takes on the host role without consciously choosing it	● All coordination falls on her even when others offer to help. ● Helpers don't understand the vision - briefing them creates a second job ● Vision becomes clearer in their mind, but they still cannot express or structure it properly.	● No way to brief helpers to the standard she needs. ● Explaining takes longer than doing it herself — helpers create a second job. ● Hours spent on things guests will never notice. ● Effort is already enormous and the event hasn't started.	● This is the most time-pressured and isolating moment in the host's journey. ● At this stage, even small issues feel critical because there is little time left to resolve them. ● The host often arrives at the event already exhausted, having sacrificed their own preparation while managing arrangements.	● Cannot be both the present host and the operations manager. ● Always chooses managing rather than enjoying. ● Catches moments on camera, not with her own eyes.	● Cannot monitor the whole room alone and be everywhere at the same time. ● Plus-one guests are often left unattended, creating recurring discomfort for hosts without a structured way to address it. ● Acts as the only bridge between fragmented groups — never sits down, never eats, never fully inside the thing she built. ● Most predictable moment — least prepared for, every time. ● When the fix fails, she takes it personally.	● Handling post-event wrap-up tasks while simultaneously reflecting on how the gathering went — without structured support for either. ● Hosts often assess the success of the gathering on their own, without feedback or reassurance.	● Failures catalogued precisely, successes fade before they can be felt. ● No product, ritual, or person exists to close this loop.

IDEATIONS

Opportunity 1:

Design a way to support hosts when they begin imagining the mood, theme, occasion, and key people involved, before these thoughts become an unstructured mental plan.

Guest Centric Thinking Tool
- Ask:Who are the key people?What do they enjoy?
- Auto-suggest:activities, food, tone

A brief discussion with someone / form about what is the event, who are coming, what is the vibe and all the mini details the host want to convey

Pinterest style feed about events where you can add that things in your vision board of specific event (feed can have basic decoration to grand decoration or sub parts of decoration)

Gentle trigger notifications around moments like birthdays, festivals, or shared availability that nudge people to start planning instead of letting the idea stay in their head.

Opportunity 2:

Design a single coordination layer that holds the guest list, vendor contacts and event brief in one place - so the host stops being the only person who knows everything.

The host sends an automated, creative invite asking guests if they're attending, paired with a poll to finalize the event date. Once a guest confirms by clicking "Yes," the app requests consent to add them to a dedicated WhatsApp group. Upon agreement, the guest receives a direct link to the group, where all further instructions and event details are centralized, streamlining the coordination process and reducing the host's manual workload.

Micro coordination task list option where host has already put the work that needs help and the guest can choose task they can help with or add their own

Host gives the photo of venue and explains how the venue should be decorated, then he/she will get a generated ideations of the how that place will look

Host will get suggestions about the event associates and vendors

Opportunity 3:

Design an auto-generated checklist and helper brief from the host's own vision - so she never rebuilds from scratch and never has to explain herself twice.

after getting generated ideations of the how that place will look, they will get a checklist of what all materials he/she will require and suggestions to add

Host will discuss and shortlist the ideas with the event associates accordingly (eg - what type of photo, reels or games to be conducted and what is the vibe of the event)

can give notifications like 'Your event is 70% ready' Missing:confirmations , food planningn etc

The checklist can be given and get sorted by a 'this/ that' game as the host is moving ahead with the game the list gets clearer and personalized

for final instruction and information to everyone provide a poster or auto generated message form the data gathered before that the host can send to guest (theme , venue , dress code time , date ,)

Opportunity 4:

Design a guaranteed 30-minute window where setup is fully handled - so the host can prepare herself and walk into her own event as a guest, not a crew member.

A misleading reminder to them about the time so they can complete the work 1 hour prior

Provide assured help to the host for the last minute things for her or get ready

Opportunity 5:

Design operational support at the arrival stage - so the host can be fully present at the door instead of managing coordination in the background.

Provide assured help to the host for things that need to happen at the same time and different places (for serving food ,clicking photos etc)

Opportunity 6:

Design a way for passive awareness and contextual nudges - so the host never has to personally rescue the room's energy or force connections between guests.

15-min Prop Drops - Helper quietly places photo booth props, card games, or other activities

System suggests : Time for a quick game? Start a group activity? etc and can give fun ideas based on mood and people

Opportunity 7:

Design a closing prompt that helps the host pause and reflect on the gathering - before her attention shifts to cleanup, payments and perceived shortcomings.

someone will help the host to quickly cleanup the venue

A board where the guests will write their appreciations and their experience so that host can view it later

Opportunity 8:

Design a post-event witness moment - something that names what worked, acknowledges the effort, and gives the host a clear signal that it's done and she can put it down.

Thank you message from host to guests with Personalization For close friends vs formal guests

can post their event moments and activities on social platform or communtity and can get social validation from other users / guests games suggestion, quiz , music and activities and will make auto generated fair teams that helps in engaging guests

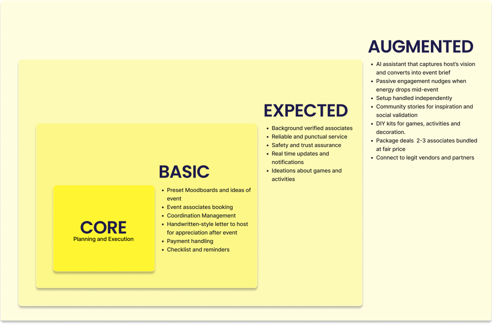
"Conversation Starters" this printed prompts will be kept at various places like near the food counter, main table, etc so the guest can take it and may discuss about it

will give host a handwritten letter or note to appreciate the host

give them a photocard (digitally or printed) as for post experience memory

Random karaoke, dance face off dumb charades, etc.

LEVELS OF SERVICE VALUE CREATION



AUGMENTED

- AI assistant that captures host's vision and converts into event brief
- Passive engagement nudges when energy drops mid-event
- Setup handled independently
- Community stories for inspiration and social validation
- DIY kits for games, activities and decoration.
- Package deals 2-3 associates bundled at fair price
- Connect to legit vendors and partners

EXPECTED

- Background verified associates
- Reliable and punctual service
- Safety and trust assurance
- Real time updates and notifications
- Ideations about games and activities

BASIC

- Preset Moodboards and ideas of event
- Event associates booking
- Coordination Management
- Handwritten-style letter to host for appreciation after event
- Payment handling
- Checklist and reminders

CORE

Planning and Execution

TO-BE JOURNEY MAP

THIS HAS KEY ACTIONS FROM JOURNEY MAP

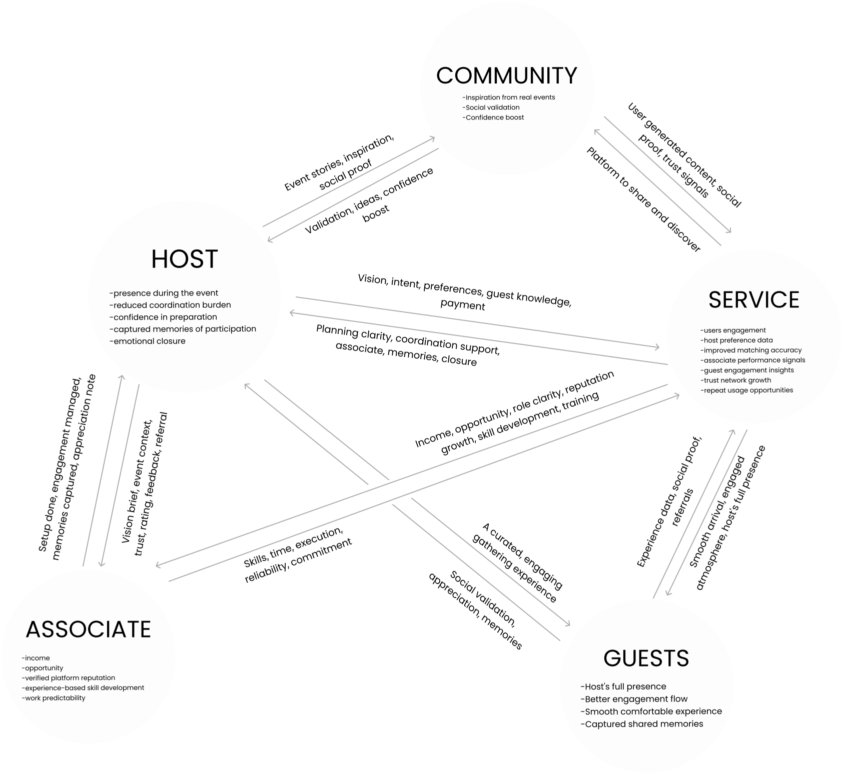
STAGE	01 **Idea Stage**	02 **Planning & Coordination**	03 **Preparation Stage**	04 **Final Setup Stage**
GOALS *(Users goals)*	To have clarity about the event planning Turn a felt occasion into a real plan and feel heard from the very first moment	Lock in all logistics without chasing people Delegate coordination without losing control of the vision Get the right associate matched quickly	Feel prepared without burning herself out Brief others without repeating herself Have everything ready before the day arrives	Use this time to get herself ready Arrive as a host, not a crew member
ACTIONS *(What does the user do?)*	Installs and opens the app Speaks or types her vision to the AI assistant Reviews the auto-generated Event Understanding Brief Browses vision moodboard — suggested or discover more Receives trigger notification at the right moment	Confirms moodboard direction, date, venue, guest list, game and activities Reviews and sets event timeline on the app Reviews and edits the checklist Browses associate profiles, past events, reviews Schedules coordination call with matched associate	Works through the gamified prep checklist Receives celebratory progress updates - '70% ready' Orders decor, game kits, gifts, and snacks via recommendations Deep cleans space, preps food	Gets dressed, does personal preparation checks setup done by associate Does a final walkthrough
USER THOUGHTS *(What is the user thinking?)*	*"Oh — it actually understood what I meant."* *"I didn't have to explain everything twice."* *"This feels like it might actually work."*	*"The checklist is already done — I just have to review it."* *"The budget looks right. And I can change it if I need to."* *"I found an associate who has done something like this before."*	*"I'm 70% ready — and there's still time left."* *"The app already sent the guest instructions. I didn't have to do it."* *"I just have to focus on the food and space now."*	*"The associate is already there. I don't have to go early."* *"I got to get dressed properly for the first time."* *"The setup is done. I can actually take a breath."*
EMOTIONS *(What is the user feeling?)*	🤔	🧐	😌	🥰
TOUCHPOINT	Service Platform / App AI Planning Assistant Trigger notification In-App Chat / Notifications	AI Planning Assistant Associate Discovery Page Planning Dashboard In-App Chat / Notifications Payment Gateway Associate	Venue Space Decoration items Activity Kits / Props for activity Service Platform / App In-App Chat / Notifications Associate	Service Platform/ App Setup completion notification Associate Activity Kits / Props for activity Venue Space Decoration Setup

STAGE	05 **Guest Arrival Stage**	06 **Event Engagement & Mid-Event Adjustment**	07 **Event Closing Stage**	08 **Reflection Stage**
GOALS *(Users goals)*	Welcome guests warmly and be fully present Ensure the space and flow is right Be seen as a gracious host, not an operations manager	Stay present and enjoy the gathering Keep energy high and guests connected Not be the only one holding it together	Close the evening gracefully Not worry about cleanup or payments Feel appreciated and at ease	Relive and share the memories Know honestly how the evening went Put the event down and move on with closure
ACTIONS *(What does the user do?)*	Welcomes guests Introduces guests, directs them to the space Initiates conversations	Engages with guests — sits down, eats, is present Participates in activities alongside guests Notices energy dropping Remains present while associate handles the operations	Says goodbyes, accepts compliments graciously Views the Experience Board — live guest messages and feelings Sits down while associate handles all cleanup Settles any remaining payments via app reminder Receives a personalised appreciation letter from associate	Receives curated photos and reels from associate Shares content with guests if she wants Gives feedback and star rating Chooses whether to share on community stories
USER THOUGHTS *(What is the user thinking?)*	*"It looks the way I imagined. It's actually working."* *"I'm just welcoming people — I'm not managing anything."* *"Someone is capturing this. I don't have to worry about photos."*	*"I'm sitting down. I'm actually sitting down at my own event."* *"The energy dipped and the associate handled it before I even noticed."* *"I got to be a guest at my own gathering."*	*"I didn't have to clean a single thing."* *"The guests left messages — I didn't even know this was happening."* *"I feel like someone took care of me tonight too."*	*"The photos are already edited and in my phone."* *"I know exactly what went well — and what to do differently."* *"I'm actually ready to do this again."*
EMOTIONS *(What is the user feeling?)*	😁	😎	😮‍💨	🤩
TOUCHPOINT	Associate Guests Venue Space Decoration Entrance	Activity Kits / Props Guests Food and drinks Associate Venue Space Engagement nudge notification	Experience Board Payment Gateway Appreciation letter Associate Guests	Service Platform / App Curated photos and reels Community stories card Associate Feedback & Ratings

SERVICE DEFINITION

We support informal hosts across the entire hosting journey - from the first spark of an idea to post-event reflection - by capturing their vision, structuring their coordination, and placing a trained associate on the ground during critical moments. Through a combination of AI-powered planning tools and human execution support, we distribute the responsibilities that currently fall on the host alone - enabling them to be fully present at the gathering they designed, while creating meaningful experience for guests and the wider community around them.

VALUE FLOW DIAGRAM


COMMUNITY
-Inspiration from real events
-Social validation
-Confidence boost
Event stories, inspiration, social proof
Validation, ideas, confidence boost
User generated content, social proof, trust signals
Platform to share and discover
HOST
-presence during the event
-reduced coordination burden
-confidence in preparation
-captured memories of participation
-emotional closure
Vision, intent, preferences, guest knowledge, payment
Planning clarity, coordination support, associate, memories, closure
SERVICE
-users engagement
-host preference data
-improved matching accuracy
-associate performance signals
-guest engagement insights
-trust network growth
-repeat usage opportunities
Income, opportunity, role clarity, reputation growth, skill development, training
Skills, time, execution, reliability, commitment
Setup done, engagement managed, memories captured, appreciation note
Vision brief, event context, trust, rating, feedback, referral
Experience data, social proof, referrals
Smooth arrival, engaged atmosphere, host's full presence
A curated, engaging gathering experience
Social validation, appreciation, memories
ASSOCIATE
-income
-opportunity
-verified platform reputation
-experience-based skill development
-work predictability
GUESTS
-Host's full presence
-Better engagement flow
-Smooth comfortable experience
-Captured shared memories

We mapped how value is co-created between the host, associates, guests, platform, and community by identifying what each actor contributes and receives across the hosting journey.
This helped us understand how the gathering experience emerges through shared roles, coordination, participation, and trust rather than a single service interaction.

VALUE EQUATION MODEL

$$\textbf{Value for the Host =} \ \frac{\text{Presence + Preparation confidence + Execution support + Memories + Closure}}{\text{Planning time + Coordination stress + Service fee}}$$

What the Host Gains

1. **PRESENCE**
   A trained **associate takes over the operations role entirely during the event** - monitoring food and drink refills, running games and activities, managing guests, and capturing candid moments. The host's only job is to be present, freed to sit, eat, laugh, and enjoy in their own party.

2. **Preparation confidence**
   The **AI assistant captures the host's vision through conversation** - no forms, just talking. It generates a structured event brief automatically, **creates a personalised checklist, a moodboard, an event timeline, and a budget estimate.** The host is **always updated about the progress** of the event preparation. The associate arrives 90 minutes before guests, **handles the entire physical setup.**

3. **Execution support**
   The **associate is briefed before the event**, they already know the vision, the vibe, the guest list, and their own task list. During the event, **they manage: decor setup, food and drink service, game coordination, candid photography, and cleanup after.** The app's engagement prompt engine **monitors time elapsed and triggers the associate with contextual nudges** (suggesting a group activity when energy dips) without the host having to notice or act. All **coordination is held in one place** so the host stops being the only person who knows everything.

4. **Memories**
   The Experience Board lets **guests post live messages during the event**. Community stories (optional) let the **host share on a platform and receive social validation from other hosts**. The photo process also relieves the host of the mental load of "am I getting enough photos?" during the event itself.

5. **Closure**
   Multiple closure mechanisms are designed. The **associate presents the Experience Board** - a live collection of guest messages and reactions the host can read after. The associate delivers **a handwritten-style appreciation letter** to the host personally. The app sends a **personalised "your event was amazing" notification.** The associate **handles all cleanup.**

What The Host Gives Up And How Our Service Reduces It

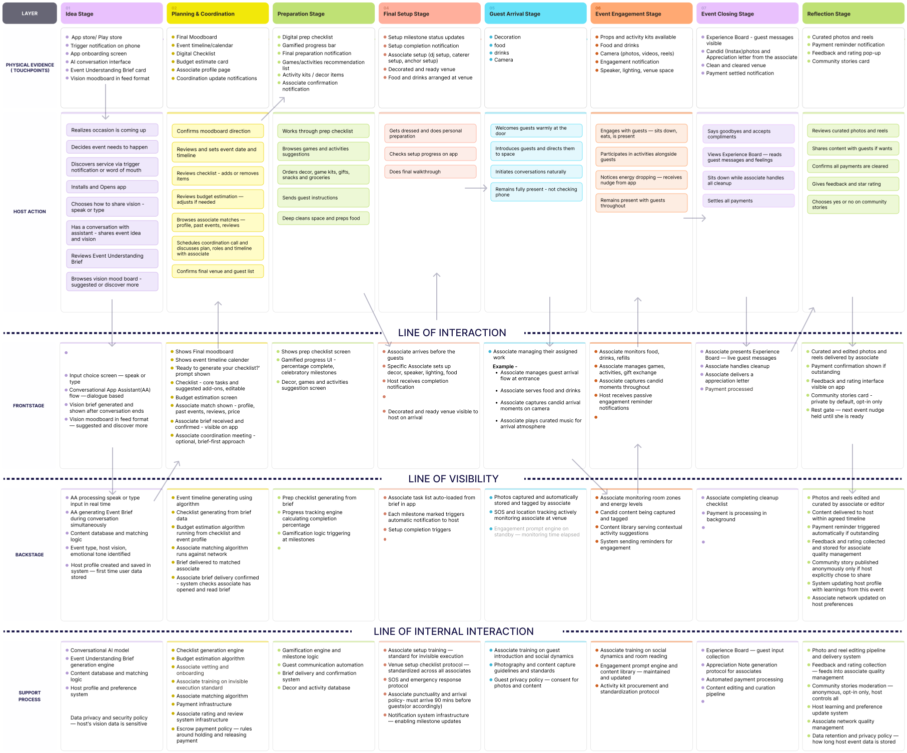
1. **Planning time**
   The AI assistant converts the host's vision into an event brief in one conversation. The checklist, moodboard, budget, and timeline are generated together. Verified associate profiles are searchable by role inside the app. The host reviews, edits, and approves - she doesn't build from scratch. Planning time drops from weeks of fragmented effort to a few focused sessions inside one system.

2. **Coordination stress**
   The associate carries the vision from the pre-loaded brief. Real-time progress updates and milestone notifications keep the host informed without requiring her to chase anyone. During the event, the associate monitors operations and the engagement, so the host doesn't have to.

3. **Service fee**
   The service fee is positioned against everything it replaces - not as an additional cost but as a redistribution. It bundles associate time (setup, during-event management, photography, cleanup), AI planning tools, and post-event memory delivery into a single, transparent cost. Package deals (2-3 associates bundled at fair price) are listed as an augmented service level.

SERVICE BLUEPRINT

THIS HAS DETAILED ACTIONS FROM JOURNEY MAP



LAYER	01 Idea Stage	02 Planning & Coordination	Preparation Stage	04 Final Setup Stage
PHYSICAL EVIDENCE (TOUCHPOINTS)	App store/ Play store Trigger notification on phone App onboarding screen AI conversation interface Event Understanding Brief card Vision moodboard in feed format	Final Moodboard Event timeline/calendar Digital Checklist Budget estimate card Associate profile page Coordination update notifications	Digital prep checklist Gamified progress bar Final preparation notification Games/activities recommendation list Activity kits / decor items Associate confirmation notification	Setup milestone status updates Setup completion notification Associate setup (dj setup, caterer setup, anchor setup) Decorated and ready venue Food and drinks arranged at venue
HOST ACTION	Realizes occasion is coming up Decides event needs to happen Discovers service via trigger notification or word of mouth Installs and Opens app Chooses how to share vision - speak or type Has a conversation with assistant - shares event idea and vision Reviews Event Understanding Brief Browses vision mood board - suggested or discover more	Confirms moodboard direction Reviews and sets event date and timeline Reviews checklist - adds or removes items Reviews budget estimation — adjusts if needed Browses associate matches — profile, past events, reviews Schedules coordination call and discusses plan, roles and timeline with associate Confirms final venue and guest list	Works through prep checklist Browses games and activities suggestions Orders decor, game kits, gifts, snacks and groceries Sends guest instructions Deep cleans space and preps food	Gets dressed and does personal preparation Checks setup progress on app Does final walkthrough
LINE OF INTERACTION				
FRONTSTAGE	Input choice screen — speak or type Conversational App Assistant(AA) flow — dialogue based Vision brief generated and shown after conversation ends Vision moodboard in feed format — suggested and discover more	Shows Final moodboard Shows event timeline calender 'Ready to generate your checklist?' prompt shown Checklist - core tasks and suggested add-ons, editable Budget estimation screen Associate match shown - profile, past events, reviews, price Associate brief received and confirmed - visible on app Associate coordination meeting - optional, brief-first approach	Shows prep checklist screen Gamified progress UI - percentage complete, celebratory milestones Decor, games and activities suggestion screen	Associate arrives before the guests Specific Associate sets up decor, speaker, lighting, food Host receives completion notification Decorated and ready venue visible to host on arrival
LINE OF VISIBILITY				
BACKSTAGE	AA processing speak or type input in real time AA generating Event Brief during conversation simultaneously Content database and matching logic Event type, host vision, emotional tone identified Host profile created and saved in system — first time user data stored	Event timeline generating using algorithm Checklist generating from brief data Budget estimation algorithm running from checklist and event profile Associate matching algorithm runs against network Brief delivered to matched associate Associate brief delivery confirmed - system checks associate has opened and read brief	Prep checklist generating from brief Progress tracking engine calculating completion percentage Gamification logic triggering at milestones	Associate task list auto-loaded from brief in app Each milestone marked triggers automatic notification to host Setup completion triggers
LINE OF INTERNAL INTERACTION				
SUPPORT PROCESS	Conversational AI model Event Understanding Brief generation engine Content database and matching logic Host profile and preference system Data privacy and security policy — host's vision data is sensitive	Checklist generation engine Budget estimation algorithm Associate vetting and onboarding Associate training on invisible execution standard Associate matching algorithm Payment infrastructure Associate rating and review system infrastructure Escrow payment policy — rules around holding and releasing payment	Gamification engine and milestone logic Guest communication automation Brief delivery and confirmation system Decor and activity database	Associate setup training — standard for invisible execution Venue setup checklist protocol — standardized across all associates SOS and emergency response protocol Associate punctuality and arrival policy- must arrive 90 mins before guests(or accordingly) Notification system infrastructure — enabling milestone updates

LAYER	05 Guest Arrival Stage	06 Event Engagement Stage	07 Event Closing Stage	Reflection Stage
PHYSICAL EVIDENCE (TOUCHPOINTS)	Decoration food drinks Camera	Props and activity kits available Food and drinks Camera (photos, videos, reels) Engagement notification Speaker, lighting, venue space	Experience Board - guest messages visible Candid (Instax)photos and Appreciation letter from the associate Clean and cleared venue Payment settled notification	Curated photos and reels Payment reminder notification Feedback and rating pop-up Community stories card
HOST ACTION	Welcomes guests warmly at the door Introduces guests and directs them to space Initiates conversations naturally Remains fully present - not checking phone	Engages with guests — sits down, eats, is present Participates in activities alongside guests Notices energy dropping — receives nudge from app Remains present with guests throughout	Says goodbyes and accepts compliments Views Experience Board — reads guest messages and feelings Sits down while associate handles all cleanup Settles all payments	Reviews curated photos and reels Shares content with guests if wants Confirms all payments are cleared Gives feedback and star rating Chooses yes or no on community stories
LINE OF INTERACTION				
FRONTSTAGE	Associate managing their assigned work **Example -** • Associate manages guest arrival flow at entrance • Associate serves food and drinks • Associate captures candid arrival moments on camera • Associate plays curated music for arrival atmosphere	Associate monitors food, drinks, refills Associate manages games, activities, gift exchange Associate captures candid moments throughout Host receives passive engagement reminder notifications	Associate presents Experience Board — live guest messages Associate handles cleanup Associate delivers a appreciation letter Payment processed	Curated and edited photos and reels delivered by associate Payment confirmation shown if outstanding Feedback and rating interface visible on app Community stories card - private by default, opt-in only Rest gate — next event nudge held until she is ready
LINE OF VISIBILITY				
BACKSTAGE	Photos captured and automatically stored and tagged by associate SOS and location tracking actively monitoring associate at venue Engagement prompt engine on standby — monitoring time elapsed	Associate monitoring room zones and energy levels Candid content being captured and tagged Content library serving contextual activity suggestions System sending reminders for engagement	Associate completing cleanup checklist Payment is processing in background	Photos and reels edited and curated by associate or editor Content delivered to host within agreed timeline Payment reminder triggered automatically if outstanding Feedback and rating collected and stored for associate quality management Community story published anonymously only if host explicitly chose to share System updating host profile with learnings from this event Associate network updated on host preferences
LINE OF INTERNAL INTERACTION				
SUPPORT PROCESS	Associate training on guest introduction and social dynamics Photography and content capture guidelines and standards Guest privacy policy — consent for photos and content	Associate training on social dynamics and room reading Engagement prompt engine and content library — maintained and updated Activity kit procurement and standardization protocol	Experience Board — guest input collection Appreciation Note generation protocol for associates Automated payment processing Content editing and curation pipeline	Photo and reel editing pipeline and delivery system Feedback and rating collection — feeds into associate quality management Community stories moderation — anonymous, opt-in only, host controls all Host learning and preference update system Associate network quality management Data retention and privacy policy — how long host event data is stored

- This service blueprint translates our journey map into a coordinated system view of how the host, associate, and platform interact across the entire hosting process.
- It helped us understand where responsibilities shift between actors and how support is delivered at each stage from planning to reflection.
- Mapping this flow clarified the key intervention points where structured assistance can reduce coordination burden and enable the host to stay present during the gathering.

Hostmate

HostMate is a smart planning and coordination platform

designed to support hosts in creating and managing informal social gatherings with ease.

It transforms the entire experience — **from early ideation to post-event closure** — into a guided, structured, and stress-free flow.

Instead of relying on scattered tools, informal communication, and last-minute effort, HostMate brings everything into one place, helping hosts plan better, coordinate smoothly, and stay present during their own event.

Core Focus

HostMate is designed to:

- Reduce the mental load on the host
- Replace fragmented coordination with a single system
- Enable better decision-making through guided support
- Shift the host's role from "manager" to "participant"

> HostMate ensures that the host doesn't just organise the event — but actually experiences it.

How It Works

01 Ideation & Planning

AI-Conversation Assistant

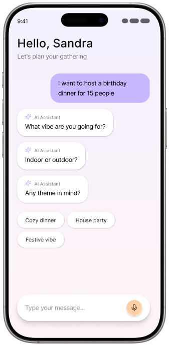
HostMate transforms vague ideas into structured event plans through a conversational AI interface.

Instead of filling forms, the host simply expresses their vision — the occasion, mood, people, and preferences — and the system translates it into actionable planning elements or can **get inspirations from Communtiy** where other host done events and posted it

At the same time, **guest coordination** is streamlined through smart invites that handle confirmations, preferences, and communication in one place.

Key Points

- AI-led conversational planning
- No forms, no scattered thinking
- Smart guest invite & confirmation
- Real-time headcount visibility
- Inspiration Ideas from Communtiy


9:41

Hello, Sandra

Let's plan your gathering

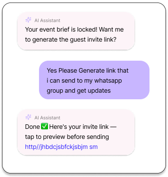
I want to host a birthday dinner for 15 people

AI Assistant: What vibe are you going for?

AI Assistant: Indoor or outdoor?

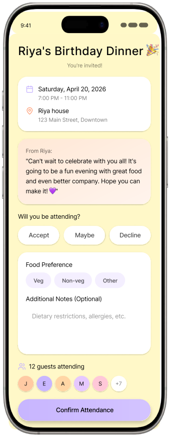
AI Assistant: Any theme in mind?

AI-Led conversational planning


AI Assistant: Your event brief is locked! Want me to generate the guest invite link?

Yes Please Generate link that i can send to my whatsapp group and get updates

AI Assistant: Done ✅ Here's your invite link — tap to preview before sending http//jhbdcjsbfckjsbjm sm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Riya's Birthday Dinner 🎉

You're invited!

Saturday, April 20, 2026
7:00 PM - 11:00 PM

Riya house
123 Main Street, Downtown

From Riya:
"Can't wait to celebrate with you all! It's going to be a fun evening with great food and even better company. Hope you can make it! 💜"

Will you be attending?

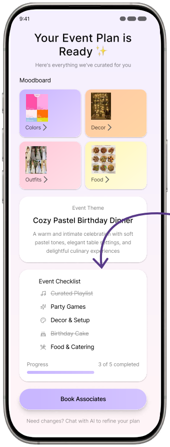
Food Preference

Additional Notes (Optional)

12 guests attending

AI generates personalised invite link

02 Preparation & Execution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Your Event Plan is Ready ✨

Here's everything we've curated for you

Moodboard

Event Theme

Cozy Pastel Birthday Dinner

A warm and intimate celebration with soft pastel tones, elegant table settings, and delightful culinary experiences

Event Checklist

- ~~Curated Playlist~~
- Party Games
- Decor & Setup
- ~~Birthday Cake~~
- Food & Catering

Progress 3 of 5 completed

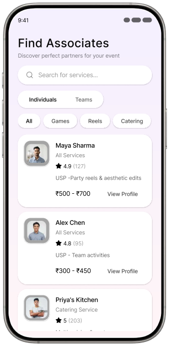
Need changes? Chat with AI to refine your plan

Finalisation & Associate Booking

HostMate moves from ideas to execution by turning guest insights and host preferences into clear decisions.

Based on confirmations and preferences, the **AI generates a personalised moodboard, theme direction, and actionable checklist** — helping the host visualise and finalise the event. To simplify execution, HostMate suggests verified associates for remaining tasks like Decor, content creation, games, and catering - all bookable within the app.

The host can explore, compare, and directly connect with associates to align on expectations and ensure seamless execution.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Find Associates

Discover perfect partners for your event

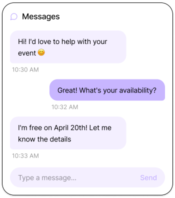
Maya Sharma
All Services
4.9 (127)
USP -Party reels & aesthetic edits
₹500 - ₹700 View Profile

Alex Chen
All Services
4.8 (95)
USP - Team activities
₹300 - ₹450 View Profile

Priya's Kitchen
Catering Service
5 (203)

✳ Key Points

- AI-generated moodboard & theme
- Smart checklist based on event needs
- Book verified associates in-app
- Explore by role (games, reels, catering)
- Chat/call before finalising


Messages

Hi! I'd love to help with your event 😊
10:30 AM

Great! What's your availability?
10:32 AM

I'm free on April 20th! Let me know the details
10:33 AM

03 During the Event

Thoughtful Experience

During the event, HostMate ensures everything runs smoothly through trained and verified associates.

Each associate is guided by **HostMate's training standards** — from greeting guests warmly to managing tasks with care and professionalism. Whether it's decor, serving, or capturing moments, every detail is handled thoughtfully.

This allows the host to truly enjoy the event, be present with guests, and experience the moment — without stress or constant coordination.

Associate Handling Decor

Associate Serving Food

Key Points

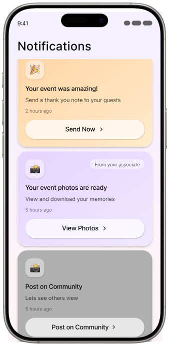
- Trained & verified associates
- Warm guest handling & smooth coordination
- Host stays stress-free & present

This year, seize every opportunity,
cherish every moment,
and embrace the journe

Associate Clicking Pictures

04 **After the Event**

Closure, Gratitude & Memories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Notifications

Your event was amazing!
Send a thank you note to your guests
2 hours ago
Send Now >

From your associate
Your event photos are ready
View and download your memories
5 hours ago
View Photos >

Post on Community
Lets see others view
5 hours ago
Post on Community >

Notification from HostMate

After the event, HostMate ensures a smooth and thoughtful closure for the host.

The app prompts the host to send personalised thank you messages to guests, making it easy to express gratitude without extra effort and suggest to post on communtiy

To end on a meaningful note, HostMate delivers a curated gift hamper with a handwritten message, making the host feel appreciated and valued beyond just the event.

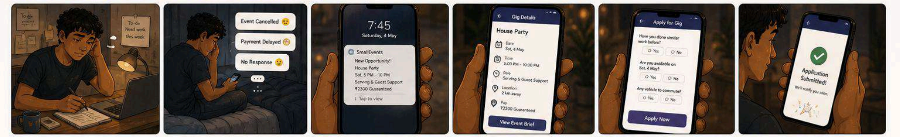
We are
proud of you
Neha

Special Gift from HostMate

Key Points

- Smart thank-you message suggestions
- Instant access to event photos
- Notifications for updates
- Thoughtful gifting experience
- Emotional closure

BEHIND THE SCENES: THE HELPER'S JOURNEY ♡



① **Struggling with Uncertainty**
Rohit, a part-time event helper, struggles to find steady work. Income is unstable.

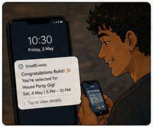
② **Frustration Builds Up**
Cancelled plans, delayed payments and no replies leave him discouraged.

③ **Discovers an Opportunity**
He sees a notification about a small house party gig on the platform.

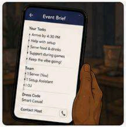
④ **Checks the Details**
He opens the app and finds clear details—role, time, location and pay. Everything looks transparent.

⑤ **Applies for the Gig**
He taps 'Apply Now' with one tap and answers a few quick questions.

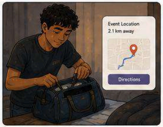
⑥ **Application Submitted**
His application is submitted successfully. He waits for confirmation.



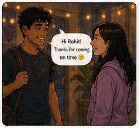
⑦ **Gets Selected**
He receives confirmation and feels relieved and happy.



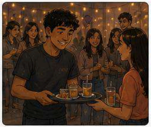
⑧ **Reads Event Brief**
He reads the event brief carefully—tasks, team members, instructions and what's expected.



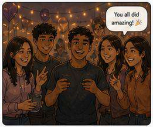
⑨ **Prepares for the Event**
He gets ready, checks the location, and leaves on time.


Hi Rohit!
Thanks for coming on time 😊

⑩ **Reaches the Venue**
He reaches the venue on time and checks in with the host.

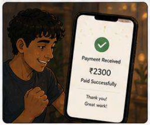


⑪ **Does His Part**
He helps with setup, serves guests, assists during games and makes sure everything runs smoothly.

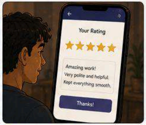


⑫ **Event Success**
The party goes great! Guests are happy and the host appreciates the team.

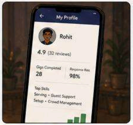
AFTER: HAPPY ENDINGS ♡



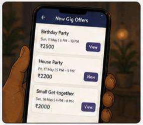
⑬ **Gets Paid on Time**
He receives his payment instantly after the event. No waiting, no confusion.


Your Rating
★★★★★
Amazing work!
Very polite and helpful.
Kept everything smooth.
Thanks!

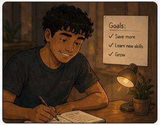
⑭ **Receives a Great Rating**
The host gives him a 5-star rating and kind feedback for his work.



⑮ **Builds Profile & Reputation**
His profile grows with good reviews which helps him get more gigs.



⑮ **Gets More Opportunities**
He receives more gig offers from the platform based on his rating and reliability.



⑰ **A Better Future**
With steady gigs, good income and growth, Rohit feels confident about his future.

ONE SERVICE. TWO BIG WINS. ♡

For Hosts
Stress-free celebrations.
Everything taken care of.

For Helpers
Reliable work. Fair pay.
Real growth.

Small events. Big impact. ♡

Thank You !!!